

Hamilton College Student Organization Constitution Template

The below document is a template that you can use to create your organization's Constitution. You **MUST** include all of the sections in red text below. All other sections are optional.

YOUR ORGANIZATION NAME CONSTITUTION

Date Updated: **DATE YOU UPDATED LAST**

Preamble

The constitution of an organization includes the fundamental principles that determine the rights and responsibilities of its officers and members. The preamble defines the guiding principles for the organization.

Article I - Name

Example: The name of this organization shall be the constitution template.

Article II - Purpose

This section **must include** a statement of purpose for the organization. If a future officer were to read this statement, he or she would understand the goals and intent of the organization. Example: The purpose of this organization shall be to provide and promote good examples of constitutional development for student organizations at Hamilton College.

Article III - Membership & Non-Discrimination Statement

This section **must include** an equal opportunity/non-discrimination statement and a statement that the organization is open to all Hamilton College students. It should also include information on the types of membership offered and any qualifications for voting in the organization.

Example: This organization complies with all State and Federal laws and Hamilton College policies on non-discrimination. This organization supports and encourages respect for political, religious, ethnic, racial, physical, generational, sexual and affectional orientation/association, gender or gender-identity, and intellectual differences because such respect promotes free and open inquiry, independent thought, and mutual understanding.

Thoughts: Will membership be offered to non-students? Can these people vote?

Article IV - Anti-Hazing Statement

This section **must include** a statement that the organization does not engage in any form of hazing.

Example: This organization complies with all State and Federal laws and Hamilton College policies on hazing. This organization recognizes hazing to be any action or situation that recklessly or intentionally endangers the mental or physical health or safety of another person for the purpose of membership, advancement or continued good standing in any organization recognized by the College. Further, the members of this organization understand that any individual or group found responsible for hazing will be subject to disciplinary action, which may result in probation, suspension, or revocation of College recognition.

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Article V – Officers

This section should include the title and qualifications of each officer of the organization, the procedure(s) for electing officers and filling vacancies, and the length of term for each office.

Thoughts: Who are the officers of the organization (**must include** at least an President and Treasurer)? Who is eligible to hold an office? How long is the position held? When are elections? What is the procedure for filling vacant offices?

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Article VI – Executive Board

This section may be used, if needed, to define the collective authority of the officers of the organization.

Example: The Executive Board of this organization shall consist of the Chairperson, Vice Chairperson, Treasurer, Secretary, and Adviser.

Thoughts: What is chain of command? Who holds what power?

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Article VII – Advisor

This section should describe the relationship between the advisor and the organization, and indicate whether or not the advisor has voting privileges within the organization. Define the selection of an advisor and qualifications.

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Article VIII – Meetings

This section should explain when and under what circumstances meetings are held.

Thoughts: Regularity of meetings, special meeting procedure, voting rules under special circumstances, What defines quorum?

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Article IX – Committees

This section may include the descriptions and responsibilities of any existing committees within the organization.

Example: finances, publicity, social, rules and voting

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Article X – Sanctioning, Impeachment, and Removal

The organization should have some mechanism for the sanctioning, impeachment, and removal of members, officers, and advisers for gross neglect of duty and/or other just cause.

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Article XI – Rules of Procedure

The type of procedure for conducting the business of the organization and maintaining active recognition status at the College should be specified. Robert's Rules of Order are the suggested rules of procedure, but an organization may choose an alternative that better serves their needs. What takes precedence, rules of procedure or constitution?

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The constitution **must include** a compliance statement:

In order to maintain active status, this organization will comply with all Hamilton College policies and procedures, including financial regulations, which pertain to student organizations.

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Article XII – Amendments

A procedure for amending the Constitution should be clearly outlined.

Thoughts: Who can propose an amendment? What is the voting procedure and percent of or number of votes to win?

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Bylaws

The bylaws are the detailed procedures and working guidelines of the organization which govern the day-to-day operations of the organization and accompany the constitution.

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Article I – Duties of Officers

This section should clearly outline the duties and responsibilities of each officer.

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Article II – Duties of Adviser

This section should clearly outline the duties and responsibilities of the adviser.

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Article III – Elections

This section should explain specific election procedures for the organization which may include information on eligibility, deadlines and dates, and rules for handling election procedure violations.

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Article IV – Finances

This section should state the guidelines for appropriating organization funds, collecting dues or fees, and conducting fundraising activities within the financial regulations of the College. Who is authorized to submit financial requests to Assembly?